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Gender equality reform and police organizations: A social justice approach

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Abstract

Attention to gender equality in paramilitary organizations such as policing has increased in recent times following numerous reports identifying high levels of sex discrimination, sexual harassment, and predatory behavior. It is well recognized that gender inequality will not be addressed without transforming the hierarchical and masculinized cultures of policing organizations. Less well recognized is the significance of situating and aligning gender equality reforms within a broader focus on organizational justice. This article illustrates this significance through reviewing key literature in the space of gender equality and policing and organizational justice and policing. It examines the ways in which gender equality reform has been approached in policing organizations with the aim of highlighting the possibilities and problematics of female-focused approaches and broader social justice approaches. The article's contribution is theoretical. It utilizes the social justice theorizing of Nancy Fraser to enrich insights from the organizational justice, gender equality, and policing literature to articulate a productive and comprehensive approach to addressing gender and other forms of injustice within policing organizations.

KEYWORDS

gender equality, organizational justice, police organizations, social justice

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1 | INTRODUCTION

This article examines key research literature in the areas of gender equality, organizational justice, social justice, and policing. It seeks to offer comprehensive insight into how gender and other forms of inequality within policing organizations can be more comprehensively understood and thus more effectively addressed. The main aim of the article is to illustrate the significance of organizational justice in realizing gender equality reform within policing organizations. Toward this aim, the article is structured to provide an overview of key research literature in relation to (1) gender equality and policing and (2) organizational justice and policing. Following these overviews, the article explicates an account of social justice (utilizing the work of Nancy Fraser) with the purpose of enriching current justice frameworks for considering gender equality reform in policing. The utility of these frameworks for addressing gender equality reform is then demonstrated in the subsequent sections, which examine the justice problematics and possibilities of female-focused and social justice approaches to gender inequality in policing.

2 | GENDER EQUALITY AND POLICING

Attention to gender equality in paramilitary organizations such as policing has increased in recent times. In Australia, there have been numerous investigations and reviews into gender-based violence and harassment in these organizations. Independent investigations into sex discrimination, sexual harassment, and predatory behavior, for example, have been conducted within Victoria Police (VEOHRC, 2015) and South Australia Police (EOCSA, 2016), while at the national level, the Australian Federal Police has commissioned independent reviews of their workplace gender culture (Broderick et al., 2016). Across these investigations, there are consistent findings that locate gender inequality within:

> …systemic structural discrimination against women at all major career gateways; the absence of flexible work practices, which poses a particular challenge to working parents; rampant sexual harassment and predatory behaviour; and hyper-masculine cultures that are generally hostile towards women (McLeod & Herrington, 2017, p. 181).

In response to these investigations, there have been various gender equality reforms at state and federal levels, which have aligned with broader gender equality legislation. In 2020, for instance, Victoria Police introduced *Equal, Safe and Strong*, which maps a 10-year strategy to achieve gender equality (Victoria Police, 2020), while in 2018, South Australia Police introduced their *Diversity and Inclusion Strategy* (SA Police, 2018). These policies aim to create organizations where "all people are safe, respected and supported to reach their full potential" (SA Police, 2018).

The concerns raised in these investigations have long been the focus of scholarly research and writing in the space of gender equality and policing in Australia and globally. In particular, it is the hierarchical and masculinized cultures of policing that are seen to be key in perpetuating gender discrimination and inequality. Research into workplace sexual harassment, for example, finds a higher prevalence and severity in male-dominated contexts where power is inequitably distributed in relation to structure (i.e., hierarchical) and culture (i.e., the idealized worker embodies a hegemonic masculinity of physical strength, domination, and control) (McDonald et al., 2015; McLeod, 2018). The traditional policing structure of "command and control" aligns with an occupational culture of hegemonic or hyper masculinity. As van den Brink and Benshop (2018, p. 188) point out, "the qualit[y] that a top police officer should have is 'prominent dominance', a quality that bears a strong reference to the masculine body". This culture tends to be detrimental "to those who do not comply, women and men alike" who must adapt to the culture in order to fit in and avoid exclusion (Haake, 2018; McLeod, 2018, p. 2; Myers et al., 2004; Westmarland, 2001). This culture seems to endure despite the rise in the number and status of women in policing organizations over time (Prenzler & Sinclair, 2013) and "trail blazers" like Christine Nixon, the first female commissioner of Victoria Police (2001–2009), who adopted an inclusive

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and collaborative leadership style and instated a number of anti-discrimination and ethics-focused reforms within the organization at policy, structural, and cultural levels (Silvestri et al., 2013).

In general, the culture of policing organizations continues to silence, denigrate, and marginalize females and "the feminine" and produces gendered realities such as difficulties recruiting, promoting, and retaining women; difficulties creating systems and procedures to safely and fairly address sexual discrimination and harassment (Brown, 2007; McDonald et al., 2015; McLeod, 2018); and the gendered segregation and expectations of police work where men tend to be associated with more prestigious police work (e.g., fighting crime and using physical force) and are expected to be able to work unencumbered by parental/family responsibilities and women are associated with less prestigious caring and "soft" roles (e.g., related to domestic violence and children) and are expected to be encumbered by parenting/family responsibilities (Dick et al., 2013; Drew & Saunders, 2020; Haake, 2018; Rabe-Hemp, 2009; Westmarland, 2001). These gendered expectations have not only been a major barrier for women in relation to their progression to the leadership ranks, but when they are included, they have often been positioned as moral gatekeepers with expectations that their presence will temper some of the problematic aspects of masculinized police culture (Brown, 2007).

The hierarchical and masculinized cultures within policing organizations have tended to be taken for granted and unquestioned, which has generated the view that current systems (e.g., in relation to promotion and the allocation of roles) are neutral and meritorious rather than steeped in gendered and racialized assumptions, as van den Brink and Benschop (2018, p. 188) argue:

> What remains unchallenged in this debate is the assumption that the current system is a fair one, one in which those who get the positions – mainly white men – achieve this solely on merit, and the ones who fail – mostly women and ethnic minorities – lack this merit … Gender blindness and colour blindness in the assessment of quality are claimed as virtues of neutrality but are actually reproducing inequalities … Quality is always based on the criteria set by those with power and a degree of subjectivity is always involved, even when the criteria seem to be accepted and advocated by a number of people at a given time and place.

Moreover, the dominant ways in which quality or success in policing is measured (in quantitative, target-driven, and output-oriented ways) are also masculinized. These measures carry some of the problematic aspects of police culture (Dick et al., 2013) and have gained greater legitimacy with the rise of managerialism or new public management in public organizations. While research on equity and justice has long argued that the neoliberal regimes of economic efficiency, individualism, competition, and external auditing that underpin this rise create and worsen injustice and inequality in societies and their institutions, especially for traditionally marginalized groups, this legitimacy persists (Power, 1997; Shore & Wright, 2015). Regimes of efficiency and audit in policing organizations have led to an increased focus on results-driven management that prioritizes performance indicators and outputs (e.g., measuring and reporting on crime reduction targets, response time monitoring etc.) "to the exclusion of quality of service and the perception, if not the reality, of treating people in the workforce as faceless numbers rather than human beings" (Beckly, 2021, p. 342; Sarre & Prenzler, 2016). In this respect, what can be measured through quantitative metrics is valued, thus narrowing what is regarded as core police work, which sidelines or ignores aspects of the job that are difficult to measure and quantify, such as creativity, innovation, relationality, and human connection (Sarre & Prenzler, 2016). Further, sidelining these relational aspects of policing and coinciding with the economic rationality of managerialism have been the intensified workloads within public sector organizations such as policing that have led to high levels of work-related stress and job pressure (Brown et al., 2017).

Against this backdrop, it is perhaps unsurprising that there is an unwillingness on the part of members to report incidents of sexual discrimination/harassment and a lack of trust in the procedures set up to manage these incidents (Brown & Silvestri, 2020; McLeod, 2018). Even though there have been a plethora of recent reforms that encourage police to speak out against gender-based harassment, such speaking out is still viewed as undermining the traditional

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police culture of command and control, unquestioning respect for the ranking system, stoicism and fortitude in carrying out the job and not dobbing in your colleagues (McLeod, 2018; Terpstra et al., 2019). This is a culture where there remain adverse consequences for those who speak out (Terpstra et al., 2019). The culture of policing organizations has meant that making a "case for change" for greater gender (and racial) inclusion has been challenging (Dick et al., 2013; McLeod, 2018). This is despite the adverse impacts of sexual discrimination and harassment on personnel and productivity (Brown et al., 2017) and the evidence that greater organizational diversity, particularly in senior ranks "indicates higher levels of procedural justice and police legitimacy among citizens" (Sebire, 2020, p. 82). It is well recognized that organizations where members represent the demographics of the community they serve are more likely to be fair and cohesive (Novich et al., 2018; Sebire, 2020).

This body of literature makes a strong case that gender inequality will not be addressed without transforming the hierarchical and masculinized cultures of policing organizations. Less well recognized is the significance of situating and aligning gender equality reforms within a broader focus on organizational justice and policing. The following provides an account of research in this area.

3 | ORGANIZATIONAL JUSTICE AND POLICING

There is an overwhelming consensus in the research literature that organizational justice within policing organizations (which broadly defined means treating officers with respect, fairness, and dignity) supports the health and well-being of police officers and enhances workplace motivation, satisfaction, commitment, and loyalty to the organization (Beckley, 2014; Fridell et al., 2021; Herrington & Roberts, 2013). Organizational justice is associated with improving relations of trust between police management and "subordinates," which is important in legitimizing the authority of management, enhancing officers' cooperation with and respect for this authority, and decreasing support for misconduct (Colquitt et al., 2013; Fridell et al., 2021; Herrington & Roberts, 2013). Organizational justice is also associated with enhancing officers' quality of service to the public (Beckley, 2014; Myhill & Bradford, 2013), evident, for example, in a lower likelihood of officers receiving citizen complaints about their work (Wolfe & Piquero, 2011). Conversely, perceptions of organizational injustice—for example, when management does not support the health, welfare, and wellbeing of officers and treats officers unfairly and disrespectfully—can lead to mistrust of the organization, poor work relations, and a reduction in the quality of work (Beckley, 2014; Schafer, 2013; Wolfe & Piquero, 2011). It can also lead to the violation of organizational values and norms—for example, officer misconduct and corruption (see Wolfe & Piquero, 2011).

Research in this space further articulates the significance of a focus on organizational justice in police organizations when it concludes that stress among police officers is more likely to arise from internal aspects of organizational injustice than the "actual physical dangers of the job" (Beckley, 2014; Schafer, 2013, p. 136). These internal stressors, as Schafer (2013, p. 136) argues, "have very real consequences"—not only in increasing stress levels, but also in increasing "absenteeism, burn-out, apathy, and workforce attrition".

While there are different ways of theorizing organizational justice within policing organizations, there seems to be consensus around the principles or dimensions that need to be considered in supporting this form of justice: distributive, procedural, and interactional or interpersonal (see Fridell et al., 2021; Herrington & Roberts, 2013; Wolfe & Piquero, 2011). Distributive justice is about the perception that the distribution of outcomes within the organization is fair and equitable (e.g., in relation to wages, benefits such as promotion, responsibilities, and sanctions). Procedural justice is about the perception that workplace processes are fair (e.g., processes of decision-making are free from bias and applied consistently and with clarity and accuracy) with mechanisms available to correct "flawed" decisions (Fridell et al., 2021; Herrington & Roberts, 2013; Wolfe & Piquero, 2011). Procedural justice is also about accountability—ensuring, for example, that all officers are held accountable to the same standards of behavior and are subject to the same disciplinary sanctions for misconduct (Fridell et al., 2021). Interactional or interpersonal justice is

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about enabling employee input into organizational planning and decision-making and respectful interpersonal relations (Fridell et al., 2021; Myhill & Bradford, 2013; Herrington & Roberts, 2013).

Procedural and interactional justice are particularly important in the event of "undesirable outcomes" (such as disciplinary action)—as Wolfe and Piquero (2011, p. 336) explain, "employees may remain committed to the organization if they perceive the process that allocated the outcome to be fair" and managed in unbiased, respectful, and inclusive ways and where there is transparency in the purpose and reasons for a particular decision or outcome, including adequate information provided to support a quality and truthful explanation for various decisions (sometimes referred to as informational justice) (see also Myhill & Bradford, 2013; Herrington & Roberts, 2013).

Considering this body of research on organizational justice and policing with the previous body of research on gender equality and policing supports a key argument: that gender equality reform within policing is more likely to occur in organizations that reflect justice principles—that is, attempts to transform hierarchical and masculinized cultures towards greater gender equality will be more possible within a context of organizational justice. Theories of organizational justice, however, tend not to consider issues of identity such as gender. The following draws on Nancy Fraser's three-dimensional framework of social justice to illustrate how gender justice might be integrated within the principles of organizational justice.

4 | ENRICHING THEORIES OF ORGANIZATIONAL JUSTICE THROUGH THE WORK OF NANCY FRASER

Fraser argues that social justice requires the conditions of "participatory parity" (2007, p. 27)—where social arrangements:

> …permit all to participate as peers in social life. On the view of justice as participatory parity, overcoming injustice means dismantling institutionalized obstacles that prevent some people from participating on a par with others, as full partners in social interaction.

For Fraser, there are three dimensions that create obstacles to participatory parity—(1) economic (distributive) injustice; (2) cultural (recognitive) injustice; and (3) political (representative) injustice. According to Fraser, economic obstacles are those associated with society's inequitable distribution of material resources; cultural obstacles relate to the social patterns that trivialize or malign particular groups or individuals (e.g., on the basis of gender, sexuality, race, ethnicity, religion, age, ability, and so on); and political obstacles occur when these inequitable processes silence some voices while privileging others (e.g., on the basis of gender, sexuality, race, ethnicity, religion, age, ability, and so on) (Fraser, 2008, 2009). Towards creating the conditions of participatory parity, Fraser contends that "justice for all is possible when the structures of the economy reflect an equitable distribution of material resources" and there is equitable access to the benefits of these resources (distributive justice); when the status order reflects equitable patterns of cultural recognition where there is increased recognition and valuing of traditionally marginalized groups (e.g., such as women, the LGBTQI+ community, Indigenous groups, CALD groups, etc.) (recognitive justice); and when the constitution of political space ensures equitable representation where there are increased avenues that accord all (especially those who are traditionally marginalized) a voice in decision-making about matters that affect them (political justice) (Fraser, 2009 in Keddie, 2012, p. 265).

In relation to political space, Fraser argues that there is a second type of political injustice—which relates to *framing* or *mis-framing* (2008). While she examines this type of injustice in relation to global and nation state boundaries, it is crucial to consider here because it relates to the frames within which economic, cultural, and political justice are considered. As Fraser argues (2008, p. 278), political space or frames can be powerful instruments of injustice as they "furnish the stage on which struggles for justice are played out"; they "establish the criteria of social belonging" and thus determine who and what counts in matters of distributive, recognitive, and representative justice (2008, p. 278).

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In relation to organizations such as policing, economic, cultural, and political justice have been framed by structures and practices that privilege a particular sort of "prominent dominant" white masculinity—this framing has "furnished the stage" upon which struggles for justice have played out. It has prioritized particular (economic, cultural, and political) justice claims while obscuring or omitting others because they are outside of the frame and "unseen" (see also Keddie, 2012). Remedying this form of injustice requires that organizations recognize this mis-framing. It requires broadening the frame to include and account for justice issues previously obscured and excluded. In policing organizations, this broadening is happening in relation to gender equality reform, where there has been a recognition and challenging of previously taken-for-granted masculinized frames with the greater inclusion and valuing of women, but less so in relation to other forms of gender, sexuality, racial, religious, and ability diversity (McLeod & Herrington, 2017).

Fraser's framework resonates with the key aspects of organizational justice in policing presented in the previous section. Fraser's dimension of economic justice aligns closely with distributive justice (as understood within the organizational justice literature) in relation to a focus on the fair and equitable distribution of resources and outcomes; while her theorizing about political justice aligns with the principles of procedural and interactional justice (as understood within the organizational justice literature) in relation to a focus on fairness and the inclusion of employee voice in decision-making. What Fraser's model adds to the literature and theorizing about organizational justice in policing is a focus on issues of identity such as gender (cultural recognition/justice). More specifically, Fraser's work can enrich the principles of organizational justice in policing by attending to the issues of gender in relation to economic redistribution, cultural recognition, and political representation, including issues of mis-framing.

This is important because (as mentioned earlier) issues of economic redistribution (e.g., targeting economic support for women and supporting women's promotions); cultural recognition (e.g., encouraging patterns of status recognition for women through placing greater value on what they can bring to the job as women) and political representation (e.g., supporting greater representation of women and greater avenues to listen to their voices) continue to be the key initiatives of gender equality reform in policing organizations.

These initiatives are female-focused and thus reflect an affirmative approach to gender justice. While this approach has merit, it tends to affirm narrow and essentialized understandings of gender (i.e., masculinity and femininity) as difference and opposition (that presume all women need support because they are women), which encourages separatism and intolerance (Fraser, 2009; Keddie, 2012). Other initiatives in contexts such as policing focus more broadly on greater equality for all, but, as reflected in the organizational justice principles described earlier, these initiatives may not adequately consider issues of gender (and other forms of) inequality. A way forward, as Fraser argues (1997), in providing the conditions of justice for all, is to begin with a focus on overcoming "status subordination—which is not about focusing on particular groups (such as women) as necessarily oppressed or subordinated because they are members of that group—but rather, on dismantling the concrete arrangements (associated with economic, cultural, and/or political injustice) that impede parity" (Keddie, 2012, p. 266). A focus on overcoming status subordination does not target gender as a distinct category requiring justice remedies but still captures and seeks to remedy the economic, cultural, and political injustices that are compounded by gender. For Fraser, this approach is potentially transformative in genuinely targeting social justice remedies to those who need them.

The following sections further explore the gender and policing literature to examine some of the ways in which gender equality reform has been approached. Drawing on Fraser's theories and theories of organizational justice, they examine the possibilities and problematics of female-focused approaches and broader social justice approaches in terms of their capacity to transform the hierarchical and masculinized cultures of policing.

5 | A FEMALE-FOCUSED APPROACH

In recent years, policing organizations have made significant progress in their commitment to diversity to support greater equality (Silvestri et al., 2013). Greater employment diversity within policing organizations (to better reflect

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the communities they serve) is seen as particularly important for addressing misconduct and corruption (Fleming & Lafferty, 2003; Silvestri et al., 2013). A popular and long-standing approach in organizations towards increasing diversity (namely gender, in this case) has been to increase the number of female police officers. This approach has the potential of transforming the masculinized/male-dominated culture of policing organizations. Importantly, it has led to a recognition that "notions such 'skill', 'talent', and 'merit' in relation to policing are value-laden and non-neutral 'emphasizing the socially constructed character of these notions and their effects on the organizational positions of minority groups'" (Benshop & van den Brink, 2014, p. 183).

There is a prevailing view that increasing the number and status of female police will assist in "eliminating the negative aspects of 'cop culture'" (Fleming & Lafferty, 2003, p. 47; Haake, 2018). As Silvestri et al. (2013, p. 62) point out, "calls for more women in leadership to 'clean up' policing have become a familiar mantra in times of crises, controversies, and 'integrity lapses'. The view that a greater female presence in policing organizations will be an antidote to corruption and misconduct has been supported by 'the considerable evidence base' gathered from research conducted over the past 25 years that suggests that women officers" (Silvestri et al., 2013, p. 65):

> …are less aggressive, use less force and adopt less confrontation styles in their interactions; adopt a higher ethical code of conduct; demonstrate greater empathy and communication skills in serving the needs of women and children, especially those subject to violent or sexual abuse; have stronger relations with the community; are better equipped in developing positive long term relationships in partnership working; and adopt more transformational leadership styles than their male counterparts.

Research into the work lives of female police has examined the notion of transformational leadership as aligned with the gendered traits of empathy, communication, relationality and inclusion. This style of leadership is associated with creating a more ethical and quality of service culture (Dick et al., 2013; Silvestri et al., 2013; Wood et al., 2008). Silvestri (2003 in Dick et al., 2013) argues that this form of leadership that women bring to the job can challenge established ways of thinking within policing organizations towards bettering staff relations and morale.

Other research criticizes the stereotypical gendered assumptions that inform ideas that women leaders will, by virtue of their gender, be more collaborative and caring. Such assumptions are seen as overly simplistic and inaccurate (Haake, 2018). This research highlights the ways in which gendered traits are not necessarily tied to being female or male but are complex and multifaceted in their reproduction and/or disruption of gender inequality (Haake, 2018; Morash & Haarr, 2012). It also calls into question the idea that increasing the number of female officers in policing organizations will address gender and other forms of inequality (see Drew & Saunders, 2020).

The unintended negative consequences associated with initiatives to increase the representation of women in policing organizations, whether through recruitment or promotion, are well recognized. Recent research conducted by Drew and Saunders (2020) points to the ongoing problems of such affirmative action initiatives as endorsing the view that females are recruited or promoted based on their gender rather than their skills and experience. This view reflects a deficit positioning of female officers (i.e., as in need of special support) and has led to them being treated unfairly and with disrespect once they are recruited/promoted. There is also evidence that these initiatives tend to advantage already privileged women rather than women from marginalized backgrounds (Benshop & van den Brink, 2014). The belief that recruitment and promotion are not meritorious processes and that women are being advantaged because of their gender has led to strong resistance against these initiatives (see McLeod, 2018), which is consistent with how they tend to be responded to in organizations more broadly. These factors point to the counterproductive effects of these initiatives that can lead to increased gender segregation and "act as a discouraging factor for those officers and their career trajectory" (Drew & Saunders, 2020, p. 480). Moreover, it is evident that increasing the number of women in policing organizations does not necessarily change gendered systems and relations given that female officers are a minority and those women who move up the leadership ranks are compelled to adopt these systems and relations—thus the game and its rules are left intact (Benshop & van den Brink, 2014).

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Referring to Fraser's framework and theories of organizational justice, these sorts of female-focused initiatives reflect economic, cultural, and political justice. They align with distributive justice in attempting to create a more fair and equitable distribution of outcomes for women. They align with cultural justice in their focus on valuing traits associated with traditional femininity such as empathy, non-violence, communication, and participatory/transformative leadership; and they align with political justice in relation to their focus on increasing the number of female officers and providing avenues to include their voices. In further relation to political justice, these initiatives offer promise in remedying the problems of mis-framing in policing organizations that can obscure or omit justice issues—that is, more women in policing can bring to light how masculinized notions of skill, talent, and merit in relation to policing have de-legitimized or silenced other (e.g., feminized) skills in policing.

However, as the research literature attests, there are problems with these initiatives associated with their affirmative approach (Fraser, 1997). They tend to affirm narrow and deficit understandings of gender in presuming that all women need support, which in the policing context, has led to resentment of women and even mistreatment. Furthermore, while it is unclear how female-focused initiatives have been instated in policing organizations, it may be fair to assume, in light of this resentment (and given the tendency for these organizations to be hierarchical and managerial), that these initiatives may not have been implemented in ways that reflect procedural or interactional/interpersonal justice. Consistent with the research presented in this section, these initiatives can be seen as unfair and biased, as holding officers to different standards (procedural injustice) and their instating may not have included employee input or adequate information to understand the rationale behind them (interactional/interpersonal injustice) (Fridell et al., 2021; Wolfe & Piquero, 2011). As mentioned earlier, procedural and interactional justice are particularly important in the event of "undesirable outcomes"—which might be associated (for many officers) with the outcomes of gender equality reform. Officers are more likely to support these reforms when they perceive them as fair and justified and managed in unbiased, respectful, inclusive, and transparent ways (procedural and interactional justice) (Wolfe & Piquero, 2011).

6 | A SOCIAL JUSTICE APPROACH

The debates and issues raised in the previous section have led to calls for more nuanced and embedded approaches to pursuing gender equality within policing organizations. For McLeod and Herrington (2017, p. 178; see also McLeod, 2018), what is important here is shifting the organization's focus from diversity to inclusion, as they argue:

> …attempts to shift the demographic make-up of organisations to be more reflective of the communities they serve are laudable but are only part of the solution to operating differently … it is a culture of inclusion, not just diversity, that will ultimately change the face of policing.

For these authors, the focus on diversity in policing organizations has been a surface-level exercise that, as already noted, has conflated diversity with gender, essentialized women as deficit, and created segregation and exclusion. This is an approach that has not necessarily changed anything about the hierarchical and masculinized culture of policing. It is well recognized that transforming this culture requires a whole-of-organization approach (see Haake, 2018; Prenzler, 2009) that involves change at "all levels of the organisztion's structure, culture, employers, employees, men, and women" to "undo and redo gender … in a way that breaks with … gender-stereotyped thoughts and actions and helps reduce gender-biased attitudes and behaviors" (Haake, 2018, p. 250). While measures explicitly designed to achieve gender equality are important in this undoing, "they may not in practice be the ones that are most significant in the achievement of more equitable outcomes" (Fleming & Lafferty, 2003, p. 46). Beyond compliance approaches to inclusion, McLeod and Herrington (2017, p. 182) argue for a more integrated "approach which focuses on valuing and accepting difference" (i.e., from the narrow gendered, heterosexualized, and racialized traits

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associated with the ideal police officer) and creating an "enabling environment in which all people (not just women and 'other' groups) can flourish".

Building on these ideas, the following examines what a socially just approach to gender equality reform might look like in policing organizations. This is an approach that moves beyond gender as a marker of inequality. As noted earlier, it involves attending to issues of social justice and organizational justice. The following sections are organized around Nancy Fraser's three dimensions of justice but are reversed to how they were presented earlier—that is, they examine first, political barriers, second, cultural barriers, and third, economic barriers within police organizations that impede parity of participation for police officers. This reversal is justified for this article given the significance placed on increasing female representation (i.e., political justice) in policing to realizing gender equality reform.

6.1 | What are the political barriers impeding parity of participation and how might they be removed?

Political or representative justice is a democratic principle that involves efforts to accord all a voice (Fraser, 2009). Political injustices arise when some individuals or groups are not accorded equal voice in decision-making. The constitution of political space within various institutions and organizations tends to be inequitable in terms of who is represented (e.g., through governance or management structures), with some groups and individuals excluded or not well represented (e.g., on the basis of gender but also sexuality, race, ethnicity, religion, ability, age, experience, and so on). Those who are in power set the stage upon which struggles for justice play out (Fraser, 2008); they tend to decide what is important, who is important, and how priorities (around issues of equality and justice) should be managed. In line with the notion of participatory parity, as noted earlier, political justice is enabled when the constitution of political space ensures equitable representation (Fraser, 2009).

The "command and control" approach of policing hinders democratic and ethical processes, including those associated with gender equality reform (see McLeod, 2018; Prenzler, 2009). The embedded "blue code" culture of policing encourages an unquestioning respect for the ranking system, stoicism, and fortitude in carrying out the job and not dobbing in your colleagues (McLeod, 2018; Terpstra et al., 2019; Westmarland & Rowe, 2018). The challenge of transforming this culture has been examined in the policing research literature. McLeod describes inclusive policing organizations (2018) as promoting fairness for all and increasing opportunities for employee voice (including creating more efficient avenues for complaint) as well as rewarding inclusive leadership and expanding what gets measured to incorporate measures of inclusion. These aspects of inclusion resonate with the principles of organizational justice, where workplace processes and decision-making are perceived as fair, free from bias, and applied consistently (procedural justice) and where employees feel that they have input and empowerment in organizational planning and decision-making (interactional or interpersonal justice) (Fridell et al., 2021; Herrington & Roberts, 2013).

In relation to supporting these forms of justice, McLeod and Herrington (2017, p. 184) note the importance of creating a culture of learning within policing organizations where "polite dissent" is valued, as they state:

> Courteous insubordination should be a characteristic that is nurtured, not eliminated, at the academy. Classes and formal schooling in "being" a police officer should include knowing when and how to challenge the orthodoxy. Doing so should not be viewed as an exercise in ego, nor a crusade for those who identify strongly with their "difference"; it must be viewed as a moral requirement in the same way that intervening in a crime while being off duty is, or that reporting corruption is.

This "polite dissent" is not about abandoning the "process of command and control" (McLeod & Herrington, 2017, p. 184). According members greater opportunity to participate in decision-making can occur within this process through embedding a greater range of democratic inputs within and across policing organizations that involve mechanisms for genuine consultation about decisions that affect members. These inputs will embed a sense

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of participatory democracy—that is "inseparable from issues of institutional structure, culture, and purpose" so that political justice is a "shared responsibility" for all (Prenzler, 2009). Courageous, inclusive, self-reflexive, and ethical leadership are key to enabling this environment (McLeod, 2018; Prenzler, 2009). This involves leaders recognizing and seeking to transform exclusionary cultures and practices through regularly connecting with and actively listening to members' concerns in contexts of social support and respect (McLeod, 2018). Central to this process, as McDonald et al. (2015) contend, are leaders' sophisticated communication skills and relational capacities, including the capacity to open conversations with non-judgmental but probing questions, to demonstrate and promote empathy, and to foster an appreciation of multiple perspectives. Such skills and capacities are crucial to navigating "polite dissent" but also to working through resistance and backlash (as explained in the next section).

Inclusive and democratic cultures may also be created through communities of practice, which are informal learning contexts where relevant ideas, knowledge, and practice are shared in meaningful, supportive, and interactive ways (Li et al., 2009). For policing organizations, these communities can generate a range of benefits, such as connecting people who share common interests and concerns, fostering collaboration, and allowing polite dissent (McLeod & Herrington, 2017). These communities are an important part of creating learning organizations (McLeod & Herrington, 2017, referred to again in the next section) because they are spaces for fostering critical and innovative thinking about good practice.

6.2 | What are the cultural barriers impeding parity of participation and how might they be removed?

For Fraser (2009), cultural injustices arise when institutionalized or hierarchical patterns of cultural value generate misrecognition or status inequality for particular social groups. As with political justice, such patterns have tended to privilege some individuals and groups (e.g., on the basis of gender, sexuality, race, ethnicity, religion, and ability) while trivializing and maligning others through, for example, sexism, heteronormativity, racism, and ableism. In line with the notion of participatory parity, Fraser argues that cultural justice is possible when the status order reflects equitable patterns of cultural recognition.

As noted earlier, it is well recognized that the masculinized culture of policing organizations works in ways that not only silence women's voices but misrecognize and devalue their contributions (Fraser, 2009). This is a culture that ties notions of the ideal police officer to the hegemonically masculine body. Amid this culture, there is an implicit and explicit othering (maligning, trivializing, and exclusion) of women and "the feminine," which (as explained earlier) plays out in multiple ways, but especially in gendered assumptions and the gendering of particular roles. Transforming this culture is difficult because it tends to be taken for granted and thus invisible to many (McLeod & Herrington, 2017). An important starting point in any transformation, then, is bringing to consciousness the biases embedded in masculinized policing (McLeod, 2018). This is about individuals (1) becoming critically aware of the gendered, heteronormative, racialized, and classed frames of reference within which they understand themselves and others; (2) understanding how these biases play out in their relations with others; and (3) understanding how these biases might be transformed through different ways of knowing and doing (International Rescue Committee, 2014; Keddie et al., 2021).

Importantly, this is a process that enables a critical analysis of the job itself in its complexity and differentiation (Dick et al., 2013; McLeod, 2018). This does not mean being critical of masculinity or masculine culture per se—elements of which are highly positive and important for executing the job well (Westmarland & Rowe, 2018). What it does mean, rather, is engaging with and problematizing the social construction of concepts like merit in policing—that are presumed to be neutral but are, in reality, steeped in biases that reproduce structural and relational inequalities (see van den Brink & Benschop, 2018). They create the (distorted) frame within which social justice issues and claims are considered (Fraser, 2008). Questioning and problematizing what merit means and looks like in relation to different policing roles and positions may reveal and challenge gendered structures and practices.

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This process is necessarily difficult and discomforting. It is well recognized, for example, that challenging masculinized cultures (especially with men) can incite resistance and backlash because it seeks to change deeply ingrained and cherished ways of thinking and doing gender (see Flood, 2019; Keddie & Bartel, 2021). Resistance, however, is a healthy feature of organizational change (McLeod & Herrington, 2017) and can be mobilized in productive and educative ways if approached sensitively. Procedural and interactional justice are important here in setting a tone to navigate and transform this resistance—fairness, trust, transparency, accountability, and inclusion (Fridell et al., 2021; Wolfe & Piquero, 2011) are central to creating "safe" spaces where resistance can become visible and discussable in ways that encourage vulnerability and self-reflection on issues of power, privilege, and equality (McLeod, 2018; van den Brink & Benschop, 2018; Keddie & Bartel, 2021). Creating personal connections through conversation and stories can enable this process of questioning and may occur incidentally or more formally in relation to structured learning activities. The idea of policing organizations being learning organizations is generative here, as mentioned in the previous section, as supporting procedural and interpersonal or interactional justice (McLeod & Herrington, 2017). This is where members are continually engaging in "new and expansive patterns of thinking [where] collective aspiration is set free and people learn to learn together" and where knowledge is shared and disseminated (McLeod & Herrington, 2017, p. 184).

6.3 | What are the economic barriers impeding parity of participation and how might they be removed?

For Fraser (2009), economic injustices arise when the structures of society generate maldistribution or class inequality for particular social groups. Creating the conditions of economic justice requires changing these structures so that material resources are equitably and fairly distributed and accessible.

Substantial material and human resources are required in organizations to remove the political, cultural, and economic obstacles impeding gender (and other forms of) justice. Creating democratic spaces and developing a culture of learning across policing organizations in the ways described in the previous sections requires not only strong commitment and leadership for gender reform, but a wealth and broad repertoire of sustained professional learning and resources that have an ongoing impact on de-gendering structures and practices. Making this happen is stymied by the managerialism driving policing organizations where, as noted earlier, the imperatives of economic rationalism and efficiency have intensified workloads to untenable levels and quantitative metrics continue to narrow what constitutes quality policing—sidelining the social, relational, and creative. These priorities mean that it is difficult to transform policing organizations to be more democratic and inclusive learning organizations (Sarre & Prenzler, 2016).

Notwithstanding, there have been important initiatives within policing organizations designed to directly support economic or redistributive justice. As noted early in this article, long-standing approaches to gender reform in policing organizations have sought to increase the number of female police officers through women-only mentoring and leadership schemes. While potentially problematic in affirming essentialized and deficit ideas of females, these approaches reflect redistributive justice because they seek to remove the economic obstacles that impede some women's capacities to participate on par with their colleagues toward creating a fair and equitable workplace. Creating the conditions where police officers support rather than resent these female-focused initiatives requires, as suggested earlier, organizational justice where officers perceive the initiatives to be fair, free from bias, and applied consistently and accurately (procedural justice) and where they feel included in the decision-making that led to their instating (interactional/interpersonal justice).

Other economic-focused initiatives that are open to all are workplace flexibility where staff are offered part-time work arrangements, different forms of leave, and different entry and exit points, fast tracking and direct entry to higher ranks and staged returns and support after career interruptions (Sebire, 2020; Silvestri et al., 2013). These sorts of initiatives may be more accepted by officers because they are not female-only focused—that is, they recognize

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that all officers may need access to different forms of economic support to participate on par with their colleagues. As such these initiatives begin with a focus on overcoming "status subordination"—which, as mentioned earlier, is not about focusing on particular groups (such as women) as necessarily oppressed or subordinated because they are a member of that group—but rather, on dismantling the concrete arrangements (in this case largely economic but also potentially cultural and political) that impede parity. Although these initiatives do not target gender as a distinct category, they still capture and seek to remedy the economic, cultural, and political injustices that are compounded by gender. These initiatives, while open to all, have been key to gender equality reform in policing (and other) organizations because they support the recruitment, retention, and promotion of women (but also some men) who are struggling to manage their work/life commitments. These initiatives are potentially transformative in genuinely targeting social justice remedies to those who need it but also in shifting the focus away from continually positioning women as responsible for managing work/life commitments to opening space for men to be more responsible in this management.

7 | CONCLUDING DISCUSSION

Addressing gender inequality within policing organizations requires systematic efforts to transform their masculinized and hierarchical cultures and practices (Fleming & Lafferty, 2003). There is no doubt that policing organizations have experienced positive gender reform over time. As Prenzler and Sinclair (2013) argue, the status of women police has improved enormously over the past few decades with the rising recruitment and promotion rates of women. However, it is also clear that policing organizations remain highly gendered—the enduring high levels of sex discrimination, sexual harassment, and predatory behavior indicate the importance of new ways of thinking about the work of police and how policing organizations work. This article has sought to do this by critically examining key research in this space through theories of organizational justice and theories of social justice. The contribution this article makes is thus theoretical in considering how gender inequality can be addressed in policing organizations through a comprehensive approach to social justice for all.

The article has drawn attention to the well-recognized possibilities and problematics of female-focused approaches to gender equality reform in policing organizations. While these approaches have improved the status of women, they have also affirmed narrow and essentialized understandings of gender, positioned women as deficit and in need of support, and encouraged division and resistance. As an alternative to these approaches, the article highlighted how other reforms that focus on addressing injustice more broadly might reflect greater promise for gender and other forms of equality.

The significance of this broader focus for realizing gender equality is evident in the policing research literature where there is recognition of the benefits of policies and practices that support all officers to overcome barriers (e.g., to promotion) as well as the benefits of traditionally gender-focused policies (e.g., in relation to work flexibility) for all officers (Drew & Saunders, 2020; McLeod, 2018). Drew and Saunders (2020, p. 487) argue, for example, the importance of conceptualizing gender-focused policies as addressing issues faced by all staff:

> …in the case of policies developed to assist in work/life balance, evidence should be presented that whilst it may traditionally be perceived as a gender-focused policy, the evidence indicates that this policy addresses issues faced by all staff. As such, the policy is not introduced and managed as a traditional equity policy that is gender-focused or applicable to one group over another, it is a mainstream policy that is able to be accessed and benefits both male and female officers.

Ensuring equality reform is accessible to those who need it is important in recognizing the intersectional way that injustice works. At present, as McLeod and Herrington (2017, p. 180) contend, female-focused initiatives in policing organizations have subsumed diversity under the category "woman," thereby "utilizing 'women' as a proxy

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for diversity writ large"—thereby also obfuscating this diversity. Like Fraser (2009) and other intersectional feminist scholars (see Hill-Collins & Bilge, 2016), they argue for a multi-lens approach to gender equality reform that enables recognition of the diverse and complex ways in which inequality operates.

What this article adds to this scholarship is a bringing together of theory and research in the areas of organizational justice, social justice, gender equality, and policing to articulate such a multi-lens approach. It offered comprehensive insight into how inequality within policing organizations can be understood and addressed. Importantly, the article illustrated the significance of organizational justice to realizing gender equality reform within policing—that is, transforming the hierarchical and masculinized cultures that exacerbate gender inequality will be more possible within the context of organizational justice. Fraser's three-dimensional model of social justice (i.e., economic, cultural, and political) was drawn on to enrich theories of organizational justice (i.e., distributive, procedural, and interactional/interpersonal) given that the latter theories tend not to consider issues of identity such as gender. This multi-lens approach framed an analysis of the political, cultural, and economic factors that impede but also support parity of participation for police officers.

Towards political justice, it drew attention to the significance of organizations integrating inclusive and democratic spaces and practices within the command and control culture to enable all members to feel as if they are accorded a voice in decision-making; towards cultural justice, it drew attention to the significance of challenging the masculinized cultures that tie notions of the ideal police officer to the hegemonically masculine body through members gaining critical awareness of the gendered, heteronormative, racialized,and classed frames of reference within which they understand themselves and others; and towards economic justice, it drew attention to the significance of adequately resourcing equality reform and ensuring that redistributive initiatives are open to all who may require them.

These remedies are promising for gender reform. While they do not explicitly target women and "the feminine," they still capture and support justice for women as it relates to the political, cultural, and economic obstacles that impede their parity of participation. In its focus on overcoming the status subordination that can be experienced by all, Fraser's model imbued with the principles of organizational justice is promising for gender equality because the focus is on transforming the structures and practices that bring gender inequality and other workplace harms into existence.

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